The Waking of the Prince

By William J. Brooke

NARRATOR 1: *(Very dramatically)* Ducking under a burst of flame, the Prince throws himself forward into a double roll. With the last of his strength, he thrusts the sword into the underbelly of the dragon.

NARRATOR 2: Hold it! What's wrong with "once upon a time?" That's how we've always done it.

NARRATOR 1: Times have changed. Kids expect a lot of blood and guts. Blame television. *(Clears throat and continues)* Steam and blood boil forth as the dragon sinks to the ground . . . Are you going to help me tell the story or not?

INTRODUCTION

Napping Beauty by William J. Brooke

Scene 1

NARRATOR 2: *(sighs, then speaks flatly)* When the mists clear, the dragon has crumbled into dust. The forest of thorns melts into the ground.

NARRATOR 1: *(dramatically)* Then the Prince charges into the castle and bounds up the spiral staircase.

NARRATOR 2: Add trips.

NARRATOR 1: *(surprised)* He trips?

NARRATOR 2: Yeah. You forgot about the sleeping bodies on the staircase. It's part of the curse. Everybody falls asleep for 100 years.

NARRATOR 1: Fine. *(Continues dramatically)* He leaps to his feet again and enters the tower room at the castle top. There, lying on the spinning wheel is a princess.

PRINCE: Ah! There is beauty beyond beauty!

NARRATOR 2: The Prince leans forward and gently kisses her lips.

NARRATOR 1: Color rushes to the curve of her cheeks. Her eyes flutter open.

PRINCE: I am the Prince Valorian. I have fought my way past the forest of thorns and the evil dragon that guarded your castle. I have awakened you from your 100 year old sleep.

PRINCESS: Hold it, bud. Let's see some Identification.

PRINCE: Identification?

PRINCESS: You don't look like a prince to me. Your clothes are a mess.

PRINCE: *(insulted)* I had a little difficulty getting in here, you know.

PRINCESS: You didn't happen to notice any guards on your way did you? *(worried)* They should be here. It's my 21st birthday.

PRINCE: Actually it's your 121st. You've been asleep for 100 years.

PRINCESS: No way! That's what I've been guarding against, a curse or something.

PRINCE: Well you didn't make it. I saw you sleeping on that wheel.

PRINCESS: You're wrong. I was only napping.

PRINCE: *(Frustrated)* This isn't going at all how I expected. Look, the curse worked out. You slept 100 years. The thorns grew up. I killed the Evil dragon, then ran up here and woke you up. OK?

PRINCESS: Woke me up? How?

PRINCE: *(boasting)* I kissed you.

NARRATOR 2: Her mouth drops open to a perfect O. She steps closer and looks up at him. She raises a dainty hand up to his face and then . . .

NARRATOR 1: Slaps his face!

PRINCE: What did you do that for?

NARRATOR 2: Yes, what did she do that for?

NARRATOR 1: I told you. Times have changed. Women don't like being treated as helpless victims.

PRINCESS: Did it ever occur to you that I might not have wanted to be kissed.

NARRATOR 2: Suddenly, there is a clatter on the stairs as 12 panting, puffing guards rush into the room.

CAPTAIN: Your highness, I'm very sorry we were not with you but--

NARRATOR 1: His eyes go round, seeing the spinning wheel.

CAPTAIN: The wheel! Attack!

NARRATOR 2: The guards leap fearlessly at the spinning wheel and wrestle it to the ground.

CAPTAIN: Stay back, your highness, I will protect you!

NARRATOR 1: The guards hurl the wheel out of the window.

PRINCESS: Captain! Tell me, did you or your men see a forest of thorns anywhere? All over the castle, I've heard.

PRINCE: ***Were*** all over the castle. They melted when I killed the dragon.

PRINCESS: Captain, arrest this man!

NARRATOR 2: The Captain steps up to the Prince and holds the point of his sword at the Prince's throat.

CAPTAIN: I command you to yield yourself to my sword.

PRINCE: This sword?

NARRATOR 1: The Prince twists the sword away and throws it out the window.

CAPTAIN: Well, that was the one I had in mind.

NARRATOR 2: At once, the 11 guards attack the Prince.

NARRATOR 1: *(melodramatically)* The Prince slams one guard against the wall and also throws that man's sword out the window. The Prince kicks and grunts as he tosses more swords through the window.

PRINCE: *(breathing heavily and with just a touch of sarcasm)* I hope the Princess will reconsider her order and offer me better hospitality.

PRINCESS: Perhaps I was a bit hasty. Tell me about yourself. What brings you here?

PRINCE: Adventure. The whole world knows your story - the sleeping beauty in the tower. I wanted to save you. It's what heroes do.

PRINCESS: Save me? From a nap? Ha!

KING: *(from the stairwell)* I'm coming, my dear! I'm coming!

NARRATOR 2: A flushed face topped with snow-white hair and a golden crown appears above the stairwell.

KING: *(panting)* Are you.....alright? I would have been here sooner, but it was raining swords in the courtyard.

PRINCE: *(bowing)* Your majesty.

KING: Who's he?

PRINCESS: Says he's a prince. He broke into the castle, resisted arrest -

PRINCE: *(interrupting)* slew the dragon, melted into the forest of thorns, and awakened the Princess.

PRINCESS: *(indignant)* He kissed me!

KING: *(to prince)* Do you happen to have any form of identification?

PRINCE: What is this identification thing? A man is what he does! Judge me by my deeds, not by my name! Forgive my temper, Your Majesty, but it's been a long day.

NARRATOR 1: The King listens as Prince Valorian retells his story.

KING: Our problem is that there is no proof of what you say. One would certainly think that a 100 year sleep would leave some kind of evidence.

PRINCE: Look, the idea was that the Princess would, well, fall in love with and -

PRINCESS: Fall in love with you! Of all the conceited . . .

PRINCE: And we would marry and -

PRINCESS: Father, are you going to let this ridiculous man . . .

KING: Now, Princess, calm down. *(to Prince)* You know it's easier to rule a kingdom than a daughter . . . perhaps you could perform a heroic deed.

PRINCE: What sort of deed?

KING: Oh, slaying a dragon would be acceptable.

PRINCE: *(shouting)* I already slew a dragon

KING: Yes, well, we were all asleep, weren't we? Now, there is a very famous dragon in the kingdom Farflum. Ignispirus Magnus is his name. Bring back his head, and we'll talk about my daughter's hand.

PRINCE: Actually, after the events of the last hour, fighting a dragon will be a pleasant change of company. *(He leaves)*

PRINCESS: *(Enviously)* My life is sooo boring. I sit and sew. I wave at people from the balcony. I wish . . .

Scene 2

NARRATOR 1: *(dramatically)* Ducking under a burst of flame, the Prince throws himself forward into a double roll. With the last of his strength, he thrusts his sword

NARRATOR 2: Or rather, what should have been the soft, underbelly of the dragon, but is in fact empty space.

NARRATOR 1: The dragon hovers above the Prince, wings flapping.

IGNISPIRUS: Nice moves.

NARRATOR 2: The ground shakes as a terrible rush of hot air whirls about the Prince. He closes his eyes and tries to think of the Princess in this, his last moment.

NARRATOR 1: But nothing happens. The Prince opens his eyes.

IGNISPIRUS: Excuse me. Heartburn. Sorry. I'm not used to this kind of activity. Not that it wasn't fun. That double roll of yours was impressive.

PRINCE: I killed a dragon with it just recently as a matter of fact.

IGNISPIRUS: Must have been a young one, you don't live long as a dragon without learning to cover your belly.

NARRATOR 1: The Prince reaches the cave entrance, then makes a break for it.

IGNISPIRUS: Wait! Don't go! I was going to make us tea! *(time passes and the Prince realizes he left is sword in the dragon's cave, resignedly he returns)*

PRINCE: Ignispirus! Yoo-hoo Iggy!

NARRATOR 1: A burst of flame rolls from the cave. A huge green head with flashing eyes appear.

IGNISPIRUS: Unauthorized nicknames are exceedingly rude!

PRINCE: Sorry, Ah, I'd like to take you up on that cup of tea.

IGNISPIRUS: Why did you leave so abruptly?

PRINCE: I was concerned . . . Well, a little nervous. . . OK. I was frightened out of my wits! You shot fire at me!

IGNISPIRUS: You came in here swinging with a sword.

PRINCE: I'm a hero. I'm supposed to act like that.

IGNISPIRUS: You know, I'm beginning to wonder if you're a real prince. Do you have any I.D.?

PRINCE: *(furiously)* I am a real prince! You're nothing but an oversized bird!

NARRATOR 2: The dragon opens his jaws. The Prince disappears between them.

NARRATOR 1: For a while, the dragon sits there, enjoying the morning sun on his scales and ignores the muffled sounds coming from inside his mouth.

NARRATOR 2: Finally, after what seems as 100 years to the Prince, the dragon opens his jaws and deposits a damp prince on the ground.

PRINCE: Perhaps I should apologize.

IGNISPIRUS: I should think so! Sit there and dry out while I do the talking. There are some things you *(sarcastically)* heroes need to learn.

PRINCE: *(wringing saliva out of his shirt)* What things?

IGNISPIRUS: Take this dragon-slaying stuff. No one ever looks at the dragon's point of view. We're supposed to capture maidens for instance. But what am I supposed to do with them? They are too small for a decent meal and too ugly for romance. I tried to get some to do a little cave work, but nooooo! They're too good for that. The only thing maidens are good for is prince bait.

PRINCE: But when the Princes rescue them, don't the maidens fall madly in love with them?

IGNISPIRUS: See that's another myth. Love takes time. Just because you can kill a dragon doesn't mean anyone is going to give a fig.

PRINCE: I found that out. So what do they want?

IGNISPIRUS: Respect. Tenderness. Honesty.

NARRATOR 1: The dragon lowers his head and snorts.

IGNISPIRUS: It's what we dragons want too. Ah but you didn't come here to apologize. You came back to steal your sword, didn't you?

PRINCE: I'm insulted you'd even think that. Talk about being rude.

IGNISPIRUS: Well maybe I was wrong about you. Forgive me. I'm beginning another molt. It makes me cranky.

NARRATOR 2: The dragon scratches behind an ear, dislodges a few scales. They crash to the ground. . . . *(and the Prince and the Dragon enter into a lengthy conspiratorial conversation)*

Scene 3

NARRATOR 1: The King, the Queen and Princess are in the throne room when the Prince enters and hurls down two large green objects.

PRINCE: Having slayed this the terrible Ignispirus Magnus, I claim the Hand of the Princess.

PRINCESS: *(pointing at green objects)* What are those?

PRINCE: Scales. . . . Scales hewn from the rocklike hide of a terrible dragon.

PRINCESS: Rocklike? Yeah, right. I bet they are rocks.

PRINCE: You don't believe me?

KING: Why didn't you bring back the head like we agreed?

PRINCE: Do you have any idea how big a dragons head is? There aren't any superhighways out here, in case you haven't noticed.

KING: Well, we still don't have proof of anything.

PRINCE: *(Shouting)* Scales! Look at them! Do they prove something?

KING: Captain! Seek out the dragon's lair. Make sure the dragon is dead. If it isn't, finish the job.

PRINCE: Don't bother.

PRINCESS: Aha! So it isn't dead.

PRINCE: No, just offended. I stood it up for tea. I'm lucky to have escaped with scales and my sword. *(winks at audience)*

NARRATOR 2: The Princess laughs.

PRINCE: Excuse me, but I've got a dragon to apologize to. I was just beginning to learn from him that *(to Princess)* beautiful maidens may be beautiful on the outside but not necessarily on the inside!

PRINCESS: No one has ever addressed me in such manner!

PRINCE: Yeah, well, have it your way. You weren't asleep for 100 years. There never was a forest of thorns. I was the one who was sleeping. I failed at being a hero, but not because I didn't kill the dragon.

NARRATOR 1: He turns his heel.

PRINCESS: Wait!

NARRATOR 2: The Prince gazes at her. She suddenly look sad.

PRINCESS: It isn't easy being beautiful and sitting in this tower all day.

PRINCE: You want to come with me?

NARRATOR 1: A smile blooms on her face. She jumps and kisses her mother and father good-bye.

NARRATOR 2: The Princess grabs the Prince's hand, and runs out.

KING: *(calling out)* By the authority of the divine right, I pronounce you husband and wife! *(to himself)* Well, she is his problem now.

NARRATOR 1: The end.

NARRATOR 2: The end? Just like that? Whatever happened to "And they lived happily ever after"? It's the way we've always done things.

NARRATOR 1: Do you really think they lived happily ever after?

NARRATOR 2: It's not impossible. Some people still do.

NARRATOR 1: OK *(Clearing voice)* As the happy couple rode away, the Princess was heard to say . . .

PRINCESS: So where are we going Val?

PRINCE: To the mountains where dawn awakens! To the land where women spin gold! But first, to a dragon's cave for tea.

NARRATOR 2: And they lived happily ever after for they made every day an adventure.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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